A CANCELLED GLOW: AN INTERPRETIVE GUIDE

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ABSTRACT

This paper outlines the development of an analytical framework and interpretative guide as part of the author's Doctor of Musical Studies at Queensland Conservatorium Griffith University in the area of electronic surround-sound composition. The research focus is autoethnographical and the submission will comprise a folio of original multichannel electronic compositions presented as a surround-sound DVD, with an accompanying html document of analytical commentaries/interpretative guides. This presentation will include the playback of an original surround-sound composition as a demonstration of the developed analytical framework/interpretative guide.

1. INTRODUCTION

Traditionally the approach when writing about music composition, regardless of genre, is most often from an analytical and technical view-point, not the listening experience or related appreciation issues [3]. This common approach considers the elements of music as the primary importance for listeners to grasp an understanding and appreciation of the composition. These elements of music usually include aspects of: *pitch* (vertical/harmonic, horizontal/melodic); *duration* (rhythm, metre, tempo); *dynamic* (volume, intensity); *timbre* (instrumentation); *texture* (density, orchestration) and *structure* (formal design, architecture). In particular regards to electro-acoustic[1] works an addition to this list is that of *spatiality* or as proposed by Varèse [9] "*...sound projection - that feeling that sound is leaving us with no hope of being reflected back, a feeling akin to that aroused by beams of light sent forth by a powerful searchlight - for the ear as for the eye, that sense of projection, of a journey into space"* .

My initial analytical design followed this traditional approach and was structured within three areas I devised that related to some early creative practice musings:

i. *Temporal Space*: the structural design, linear organisation, and motion of musical events (gestures) through time
ii. *Registral Space*: the registral placement of sonic material, the intervallic distance between pitched material (harmonic structures), and the textural arrangement (density) of timbres and musical gesture
iii. *Locational Space*: the spatial placement and projection (including distance and perspective) of musical events within the stereo or surround sound performance/listening environment

However, over time questions regarding listener accessibility and comprehension emerged which have since challenged my initial analytical design and approach.

2. THE COMPOSER'S INTENTION

The impetus for this questioning has been influenced by Leigh Landy's 'Intention/Reception' project which concerns an investigation into the relationship between composer intention and listener response of electro-acoustic compositions [5]. At the heart of this project is Landy's own questioning about accessibility and his concept called the "something to hold on to" factor in timbral composition. Meaning, that many sound-based works possessed characteristics that could provide listeners with a listening strategy allowing them to understand and ultimately appreciate these works [3]. This, for myself and many other composers, is an obvious approach to the construction and design of a piece of music, but what Landy is rightly identifying is the lack of information listeners receive about a piece of abstract music in program notes and liner sleeves that would enhance their listening experience. In most cases these writings focus on the construction and technical aspects of the work as opposed to the articulation of musical content and structuring devices that can be shared with or discovered by the listener [3].

In 1994 Landy established the following categories for electro-acoustic works in which the timbral dimension outweighed that of melody or other traditional musical aspects for the "something to hold on to" project [3]:

i. Some parameters for a start: dynamics, space, pitch, and/or rhythm
ii. homogeneity of sounds and the search for new sounds, e.g. pieces based on one or a few pitches, homogeneous textures, new sounds, and the voice and the special case of a live instrument plus recorded sound
iii. textures not exceeding four sound types at once
iv. Programs, some are real but many are imaginary, e.g. nature, recycled music and "anecdotal music," and acousmatic tales
v. others not yet discovered

A second concept of Landy's in relation to the access and appreciation of electro-acoustic art music is that of *dramaturgy*. This is a term borrowed from the theatre arts and is more involved with the question of 'why' something takes place and in what contexts, rather

1 As defined by Simon Emmerson and Dennis Smalley [1]: "Music in which electronic technology, now primarily computer-based, is used to access, generate, explore and configure sound materials, and in which loudspeakers are the prime medium of transmission".

than, but not exclusively to, the 'what' or 'how' of the composition [3]. *Dramaturgy,* therefore may "contain a composer's ideas, motivations, inspirations and aspirations as well as the development of these during the composition of the work" [5]

Rob Weale's 2005 "Intention/Reception" project further explored and expanded upon Landy's original categories to include detailed elements and extrinsic information [5]:

A) Real-world sounds: (i) Source/cause, (ii) Voice, (iii) Location
B) Parameters of sound: (i) Timbral quality, (ii) Spatiality, (iii) Dynamics, (iv) Movement, (v) Morphology, (vi) Pitch, (vii) Rhythm
C) Structure: (i) Narrative (real world), (ii) Narrative (acoustic), (iii) Layers of sound, (iv) Juxtaposition of sound (real-world), (v) Juxtaposition of sound (acoustic)
D) Transformation: (i) Static transformation, (ii) Dynamic transformation
E) Homogeneity of sounds: (i) Real-world sounds, (ii) Parameters of sounds
F) Extrinsic information: (i) Title, (ii) Dramaturgy

3. FORGING A WORKABLE FRAMEWORK

Terminology and classification play a large role in developing an analytical framework and I don't believe a standardised format has yet been developed that caters for composers of differing genres[2]. My own framework certainly draws on the ideas of others and how best those ideas can be adapted for my own music. The following comprises a combination of my earlier analytical thinking, Weale's I/R project categories and specific concepts borrowed from Denis Smalley's influential 1997 article *Spectromorphology: Explaining Sound-shapes.* This is the outcome:

A) *Extrinsic Information:*
   (i) Title
   (ii) Dramaturgy[3]
B) *Sonic Elements:*
   (i) Timbre – sound sources / material
   (ii) Pitch – horizontal and vertical
   (iii) Rhythm and duration
   (iv) Dynamics
   (v) Morphology
C) *Temporal Space*:
   (i) Structural design, levels and functions
   (ii) Motion and direction
   (iii) Gesture behaviour and transformation
   (iv) Texture motion
D) *Spectral Space:*
   (i) Registral framework and placement of sonic material
   (ii) Density and textural design including distance perspective
E) *Spatiality*:
   (i) Localisation and motion[4]
   (ii) Perspective – dimensions and focus
   (iii) Spatial texture

This is by no means a definitive analytical framework, but for the purposes of my autoethnographic study and an attempt to assist the listener in the 'reception of communicative intentions' [3] of my own music, I feel it is quite sufficient and covers all aspects of my current compositional thinking and creative practice.

To illustrate the application of this framework (and gain response from readers/listeners), I have provided some analytical/interpretative information in the appendix pertaining to my composition *A Cancelled Glow.* Stereo audio examples are referenced to illustrate my compositional intentions culminating in a presentation of the entire work in Quicktime surround-sound.

4. REFERENCES

[1] Emmerson, Simon and Smally, Dennis. 2001. Electro-acoustic Music. Grove Music Online. Viewed 6 May 2010 http://www.oxfordmusiconline.com/subscriber/article/grove/music/08695

[2] Lelio Camilleri and Denis Smalley. 1998. The Analysis of Electroacoustic Music: Introduction. *Journal of New Music Research.* Vol. 27, No.1 & 2: pp. 3-12

[3] Landy, Leigh. 2007. *Understanding the Art of Sound Organisation*. Cambridge, Mass.: MIT Press.

[4] Smalley, Dennis. 1997. Spectromorphology: Explaining Sound Shapes. *Organised Sound.* Vol. 2, No. 2: pp. 107-126.

[5] Weale, Rob. 2006. Discovering How Accessible Electroacoustic Music Can Be: The Intention/Reception Project. *Organised Sound.* Vol. 11, No. 2: pp. 189-200.

[6] Wishart, Trevor. 1986. Sound Symbols and Landscapes. In Simon Emmerson (ed.) *The Language of Electroacoustic Music,* pp. 41-60. Basingstoke: The Macmillan Press.

[7] Wishart, Trevor. 1994. *Audible Design: A Plain and Easy Introduction to Practical Sound Composition*. York: Orpheus the Pantomime.

[8] Wishart, Trevor. 1996. On Sonic Art (Second edition, edited by Simon Emmerson). Amsterdam: Harwood Academic Publishers.

[9] Varèse, Edgard.1936. The Liberation of Sound. In Christoph Fox and Daniel Warner (ed.) *Audio Culture:Readings in Modern Music*. pp.17-24. New York: Continuum.

2 A selection of conceptual designs, frameworks and composition guides are discussed in: Camilleri & Smalley [2], Landy [3], Smalley [4], Weale [5], Wishart [6,7].

3 To assist in formulating my own decisions regarding this aspect of the framework I have borrowed and adapted some of Weale's 'composer intentions' questions [5, Appendix].

4 A detailed explanation of motion types is presented in Trevor Wishart's *On Sonic Art* [8], pp. 191-235.

APPENDIX

A Cancelled Glow by Stephen Stanfield

for 4-channel surround

Duration: 5' 24”

A) *Extrinsic Information:*			
(i) Title		• The sound sources contained in this piece were the primary inspirational aspects for the title, in particular the names of two composers who were pioneers in exploring 'new' sounds from the piano. The title, as intriguing as it is, is simply an anagram of 'John Cage and Henry Cowell'. Ironically however it does reflect the dramatic intention of the piece.	
(ii) Dramaturgy *Where did the inspiration to create this particular composition come from?* *What are my communicative intentions concerning this particular composition?* *What is the composition's narrative discourse, if any?* *What aspects or elements of the composition should the listener hold on to? (a recognisable sound/gesture, structure, narrative, etc.)*		• Initially the inspiration for the piece emerged from improvising with the sound sources that were to be employed – inside piano hits, string plucks, scrapes and prepared piano samples. As the piece evolved the narrative idea of 'oppression' came to the forefront – the feeling of an omnipresent darkness rapidly exhuming the light, seemingly unstoppable and never ending, until a point of arrival is finally reached and the tension gradually dissolves until calm is once again arrived at. The main 'normal' piano motive acts as a question, probing and interrogating, seeking an answer...finding possibilities...and then...finding none...	
B) *Sonic Elements:*			
(i) Timbre - sound sources / material		• piano sample library: inside piano scrapes, plucks and hits; prepared piano – based on John Cage's *Sonatas and Interludes* preparations; 'normal' sampled piano.	Audio Ex. 1
		• glitch/noise percussive sounds	Audio Ex. 2
		• various signal processing of sampled sounds	Audio Ex. 3
(ii) Pitch – horizontal and vertical		• melodic motive & chords built on the pitch-set: D – E – Bb – Gb – C – F – Eb – Db (0,2,8,4,10,3,1,11); derivations generated by Matrix Maker ; this pitch-set operates at a micro (motivic) and macro (quasi-structural) level	Audio Ex. 4 Audio Ex. 5
		• 'accidental' harmony – result of layered melodies / lines / drones	Audio Ex. 6
(iii) Rhythm and duration		• underlying pulse throughout → pitch rhythms/durations drawn from pre-determined matrices derived from random number generation using the units of 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 (at there lowest denomination these figures represent 16th notes/semiquavers)	Audio Ex. 7
		• ordered percussion patterns → variations (x 3)	Audio Ex. 8
(iv) Dynamics		• reasonably constant dynamic shape throughout • micro level shifts in dynamics	
(v) Morphology		• development/transformation of pitch-set material • application of signal processing	Audio Ex. 9

C) *Temporal Space*:

(i) Structural design, levels and functions	• binary structure → approximate Golden Section proportions (0'00" - 3'32" - 5'30") • section 1 gradually increases in density and intensity as motives and gestures transform and increase in tension • section 2 commences at the conclusion of frenzied musical activity and settles into a dissolving texture of a descending melodic line, isorhythms & isomelos, a subtractive percussion sequence and register extreme sustained lines/drones
(ii) Motion and direction	• a general propulsion to the Golden Section (3'32") and then a decrease in motion until the end (5'30") • overall there is a reciprocal motion → pitch ascension to the GS and then a descending motion to the conclusion • internally (individual background lines) there exists a prominent centric/cyclic motion
(iii) Gesture behaviour and transformation	• 'normal' piano figure develops into rapid a ascending figure toward the end of section 1, before augmenting durationally and descending during the course of section 2 • percussion patterns gradually transform through durational subtractive and superimposed variations • bell-tone motive undergoes rhythmic augmentation in the second section
(iv) Texture motion	• a layered textural development → an increasing density towards section 2 before a rapid textural decelerando during which the piece dissolves

D) *Spectral Space:*

(i) Registral framework and placement of sonic material	• quite a full registral encompassing, although upper register material can be more dominant than lower register material at times
(ii) Density and textural design including distance perspective	• gradually increases in density (and tension) until the GS at 3'32" then begins to dissolve towards the conclusion. • much of the source material is dense within itself and contributes further to the density and tension of the whole work • variations in foreground-background perspective contribute to the textural design

E) *Spatiality*:

(i) Localisation and motion	• mixture of predetermined and intuitional spatial placements / movements → location of sonic materials is influenced by the character of the musical gesture and the desired perspective of the material (foreground, middle ground, background) • counterpoint of: fixed space, direct and cyclic motion
(ii) Perspective – dimension and focus	• 'normal' piano gesture remains prominent for the most part, background material becomes prominent towards the end of section 1 and the conclusion of the piece
(iii) Spatial texture	• reasonably complex throughout – minimal variations